



OWL MOON



by Jane Yolen
illustrated by John Schoenherr



Imagine if every preschool child received a book in his or her home every month for the first five years of life. Imagine the excitement those children would feel receiving those gifts. Imagine if this sixty-volume library was absolutely free to the children and their families! Now imagine that this is a reality.

Dolly Parton's Imagination Library is a unique program that began in Dolly's home county in 1996. It mails a new, age-appropriate book into the homes of children every month from birth to age five. Dolly wanted her program to be a personal gift for all children that goes directly to them.

Dolly's Imagination Library is designed to inspire the love of reading and learning in children by spending time with family and friends sharing these wonderful books together. Dolly understands that reading is the key to a strong education, and that a child's imagination is the center of his or her dreams and creativity. By combining the two, this program inspires children to dream more, learn more, care more, and be more.

Dolly's Imagination Library was such a success that she decided to allow replication of the program in communities across the United States, Canada, and the United Kingdom. At the heart of this effort are the local sponsors who register the children and cover the cost of the books and the postage. The generosity of these local organizations makes these books free of charge to participating families. The sponsor's name appears on every book label, so the families receiving the books can recognize and appreciate who is offering this gift to their children every month.



*Would you like to help your
local sponsor?*

*Donate to them, volunteer for
them, and read to your child!*

TO LEARN MORE ABOUT
THE PROGRAM,
VISIT DOLLY'S IMAGINATION
LIBRARY'S WEBSITE AT
WWW.IMAGINATIONLIBRARY.COM

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If your child is already receiving this gift of books, and you move, please remember to contact your local sponsor and change your address.



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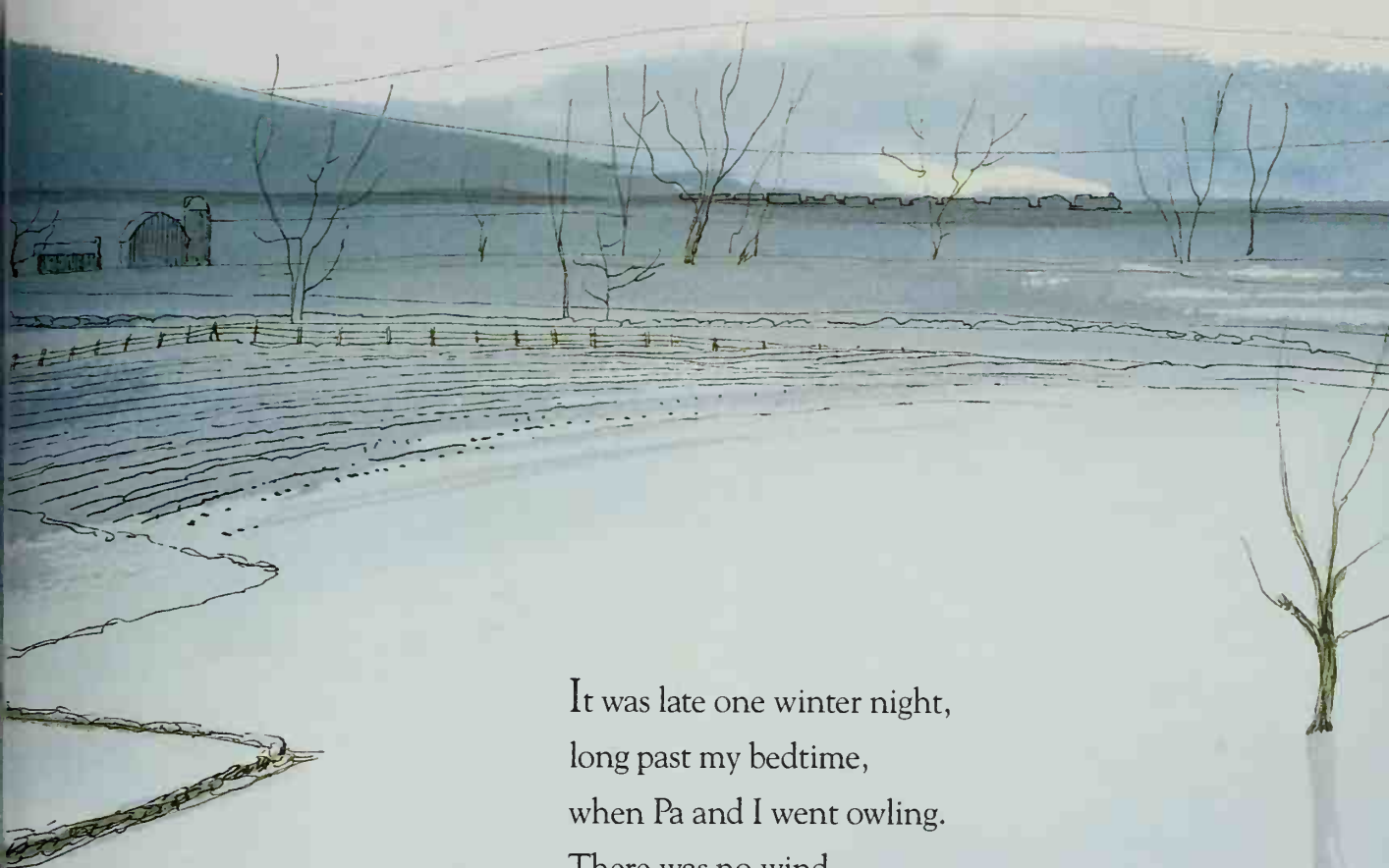


For my husband, David,
who took all of our children owling -J.Y.

To my granddaughter, Nyssa,
for when she is old enough to go owling. -J.S.

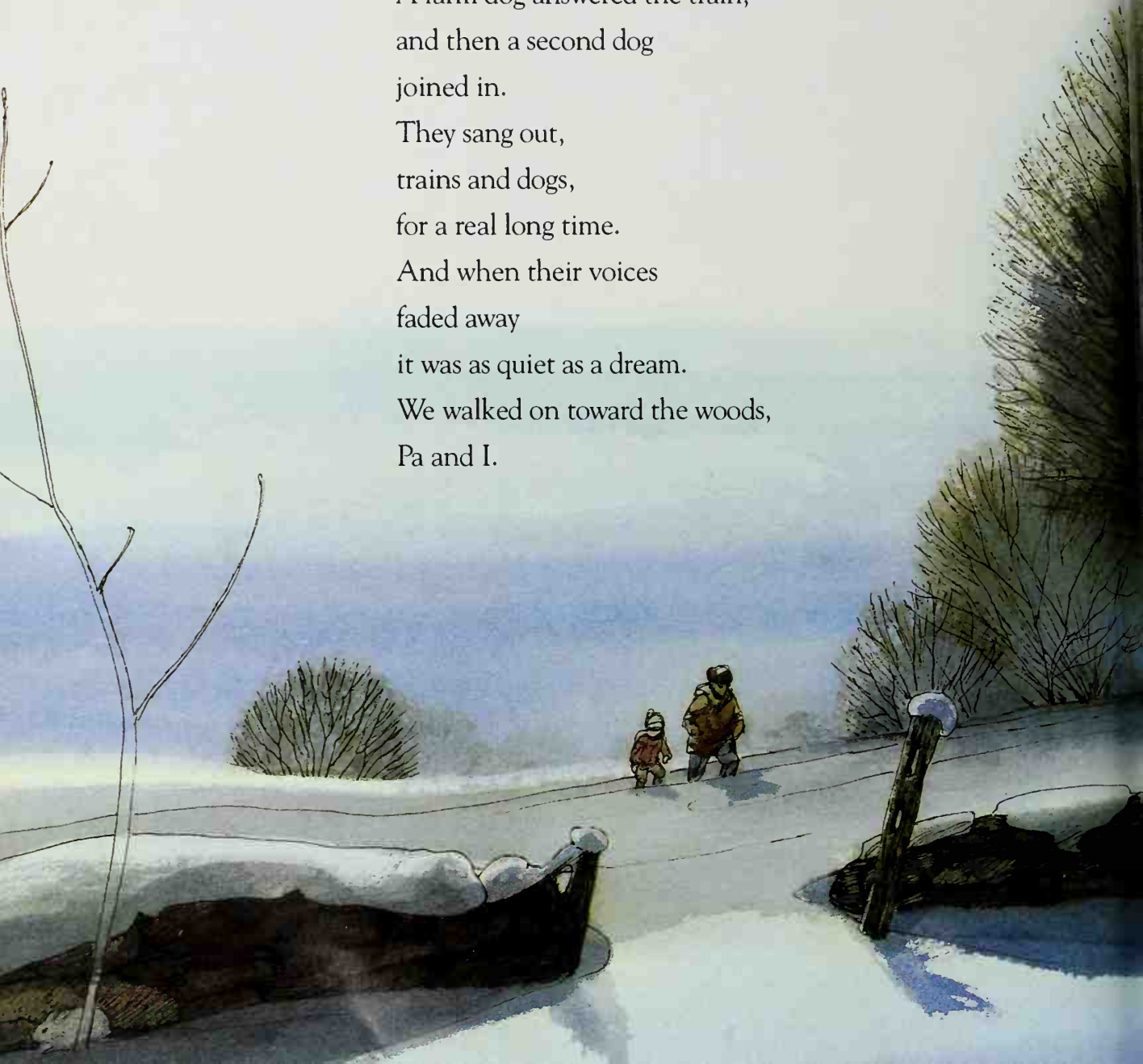


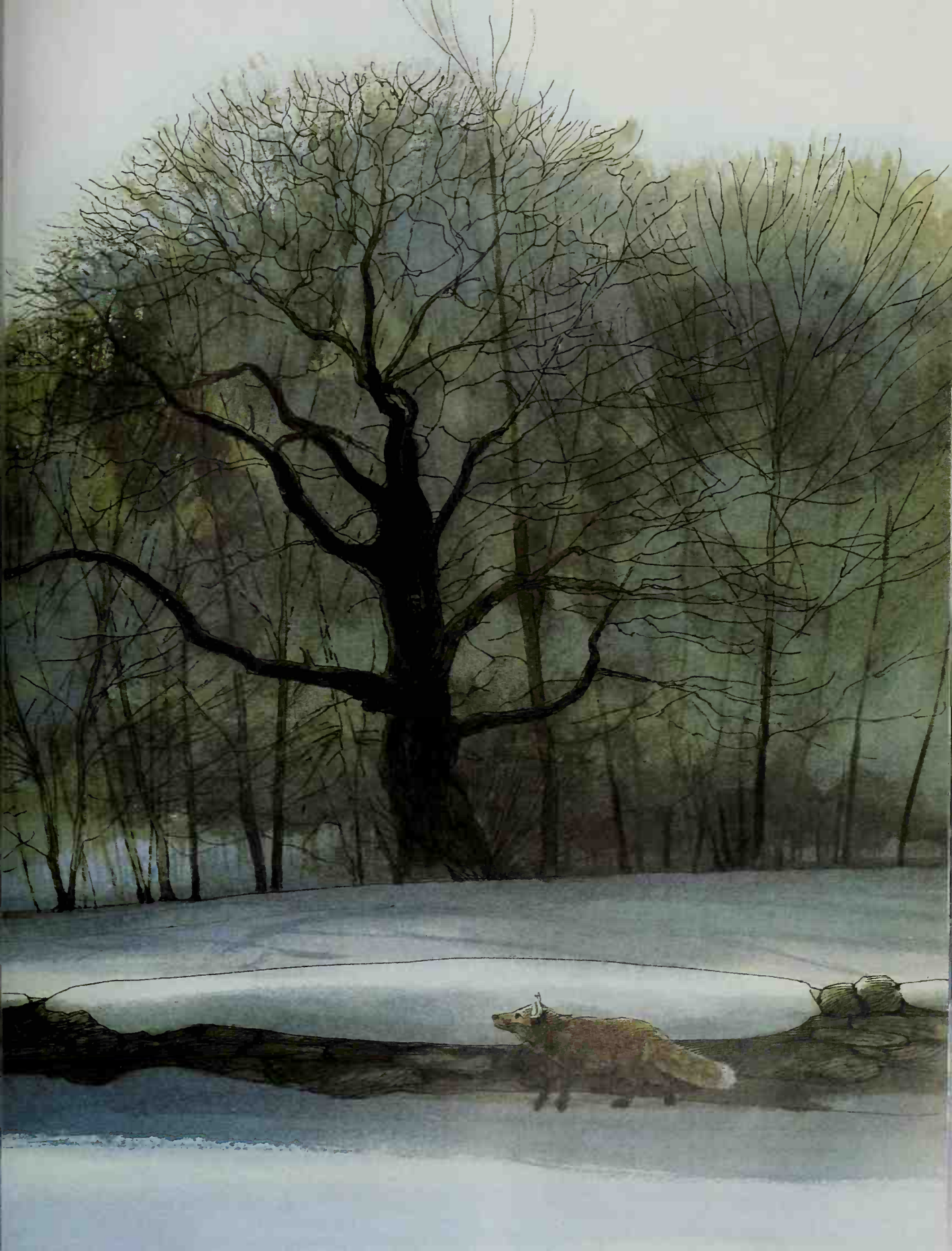




It was late one winter night,
long past my bedtime,
when Pa and I went owling.
There was no wind.
The trees stood still
as giant statues.
And the moon was so bright
the sky seemed to shine.
Somewhere behind us
a train whistle blew,
long and low,
like a sad, sad song.

I could hear it
through the woolen cap
Pa had pulled down
over my ears.
A farm dog answered the train,
and then a second dog
joined in.
They sang out,
trains and dogs,
for a real long time.
And when their voices
faded away
it was as quiet as a dream.
We walked on toward the woods,
Pa and I.

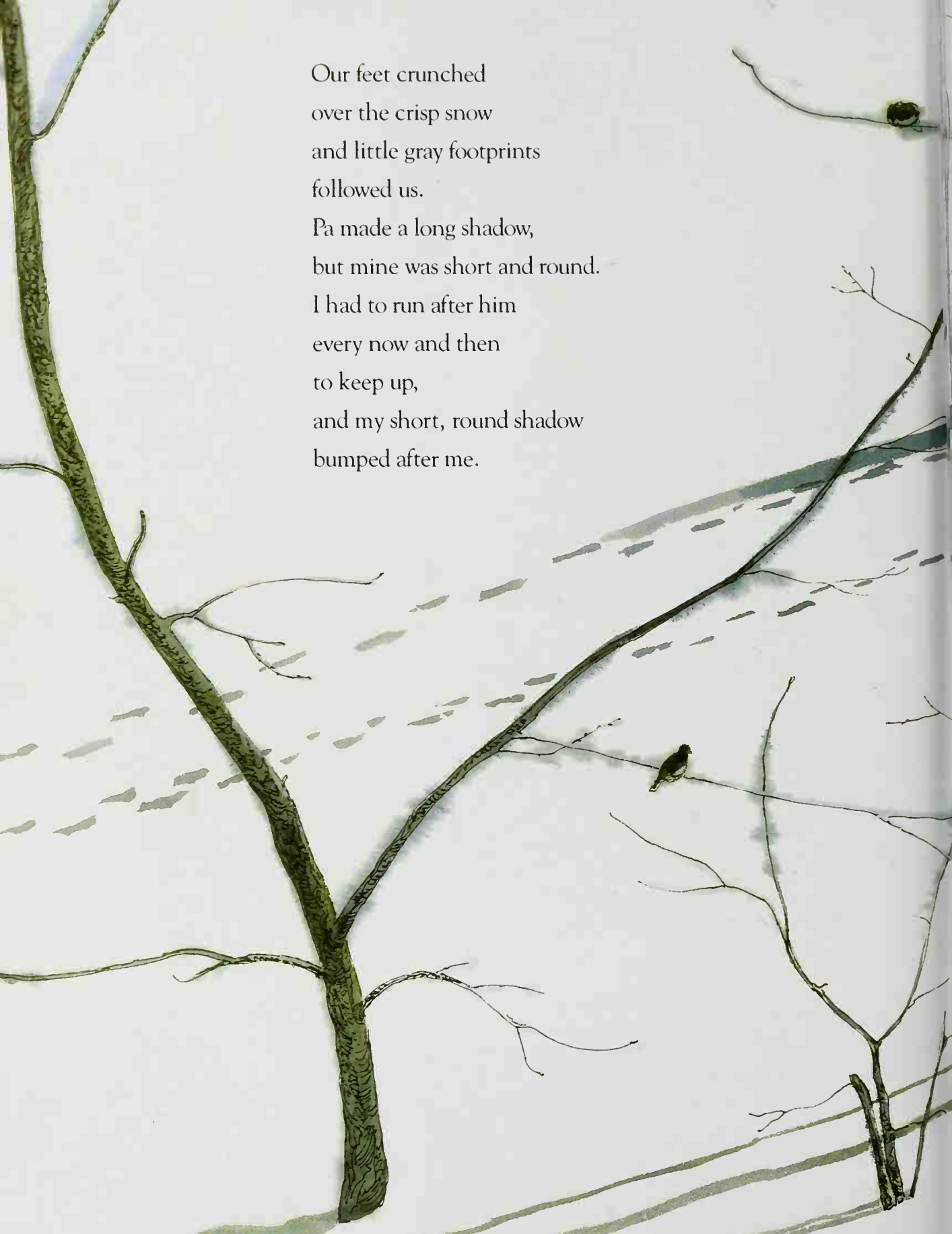


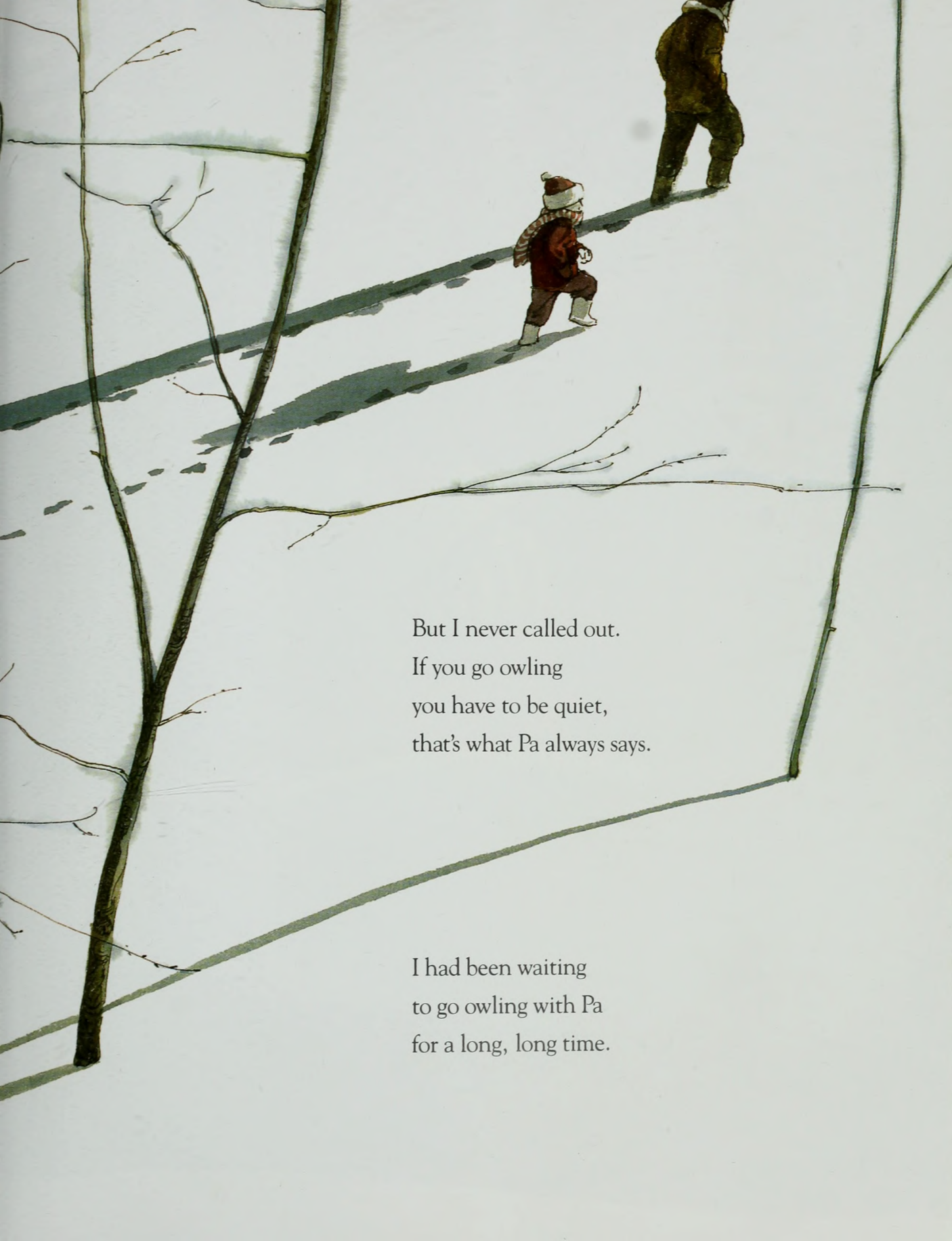


Our feet crunched
over the crisp snow
and little gray footprints
followed us.

Pa made a long shadow,
but mine was short and round.

I had to run after him
every now and then
to keep up,
and my short, round shadow
bumped after me.

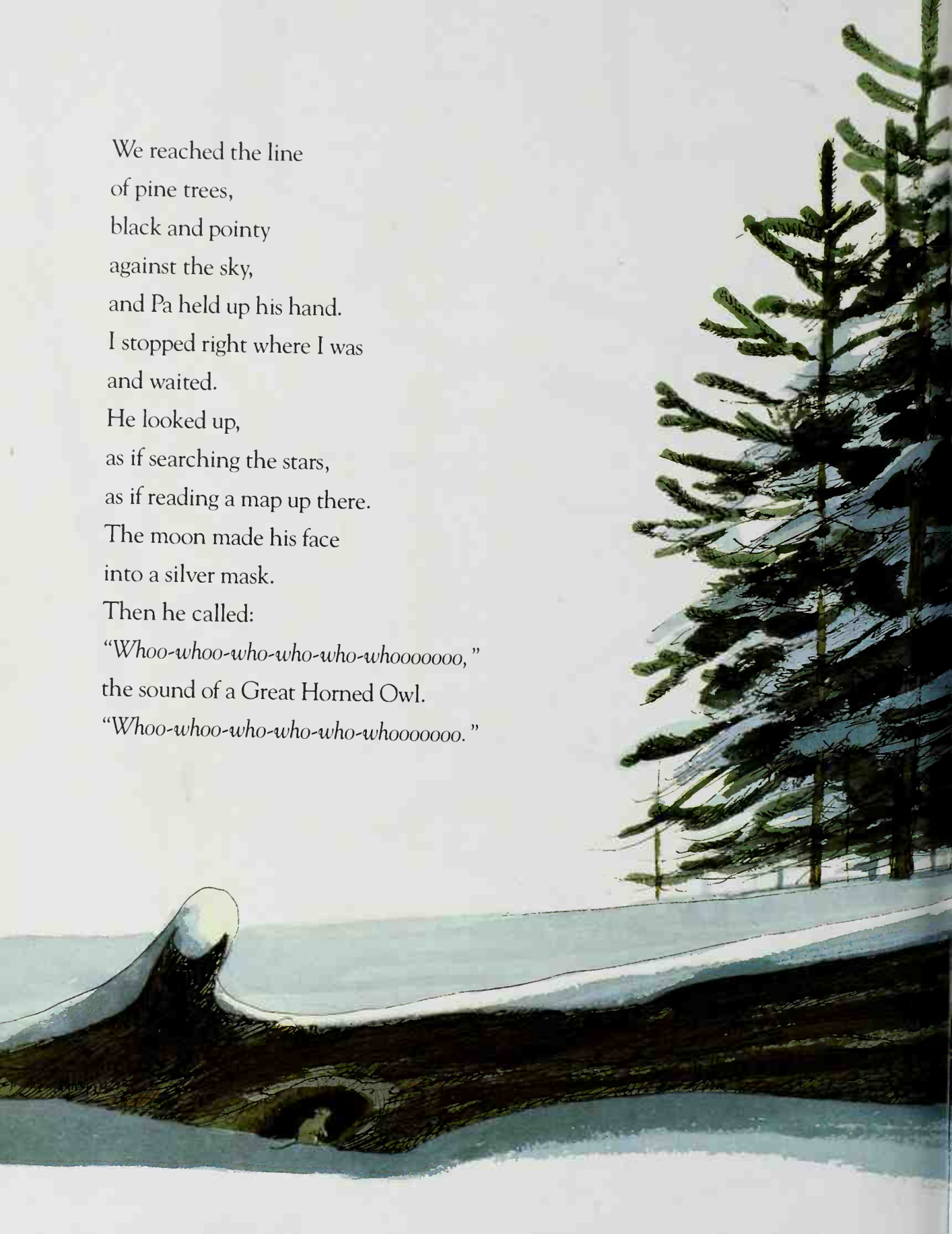




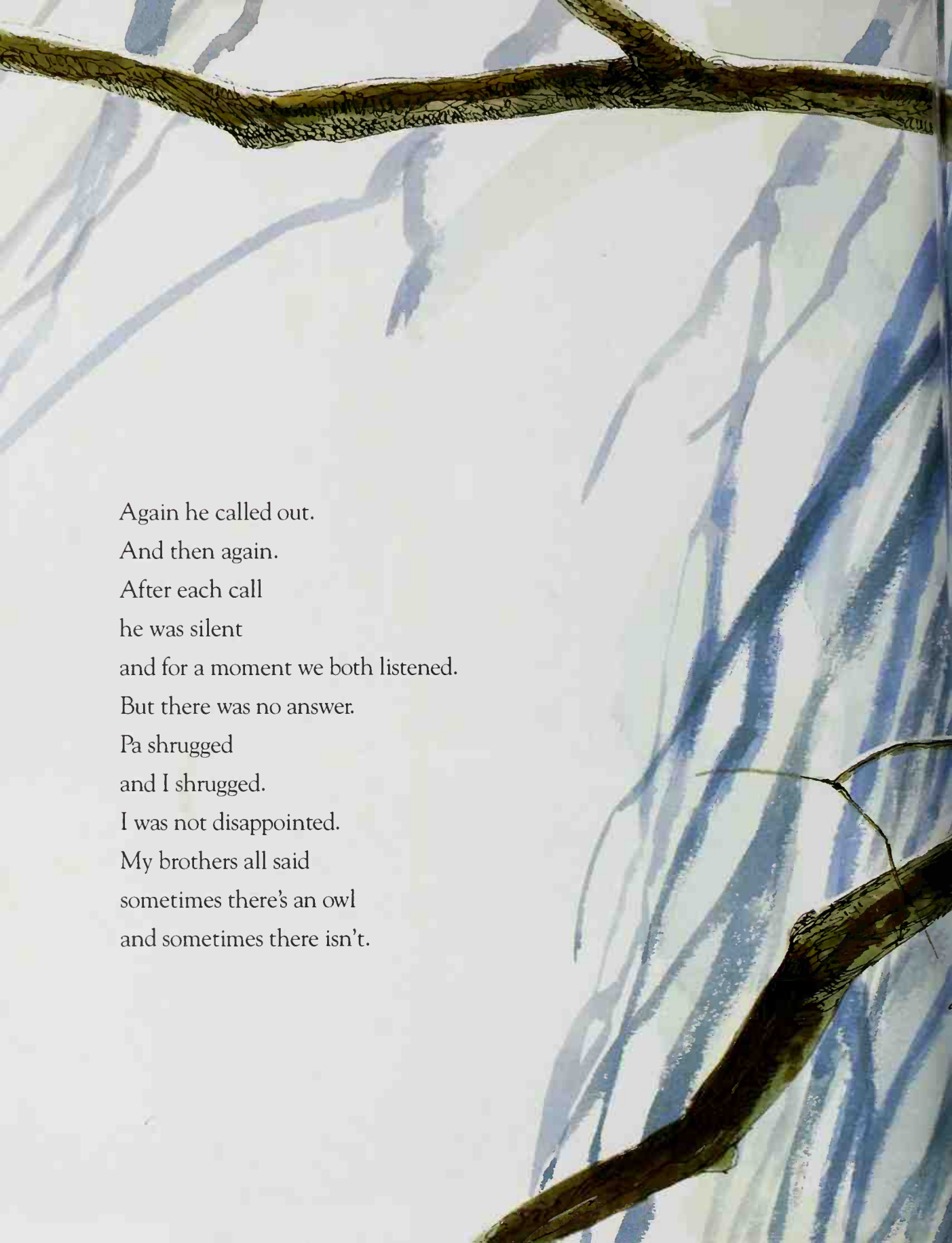
But I never called out.
If you go owling
you have to be quiet,
that's what Pa always says.

I had been waiting
to go owling with Pa
for a long, long time.

We reached the line
of pine trees,
black and pointy
against the sky,
and Pa held up his hand.
I stopped right where I was
and waited.
He looked up,
as if searching the stars,
as if reading a map up there.
The moon made his face
into a silver mask.
Then he called:
"Whoo-whoo-who-who-who-whoooooooo,"
the sound of a Great Horned Owl.
"Whoo-whoo-who-who-who-whoooooooo."







Again he called out.
And then again.
After each call
he was silent
and for a moment we both listened.
But there was no answer.
Pa shrugged
and I shrugged.
I was not disappointed.
My brothers all said
sometimes there's an owl
and sometimes there isn't.

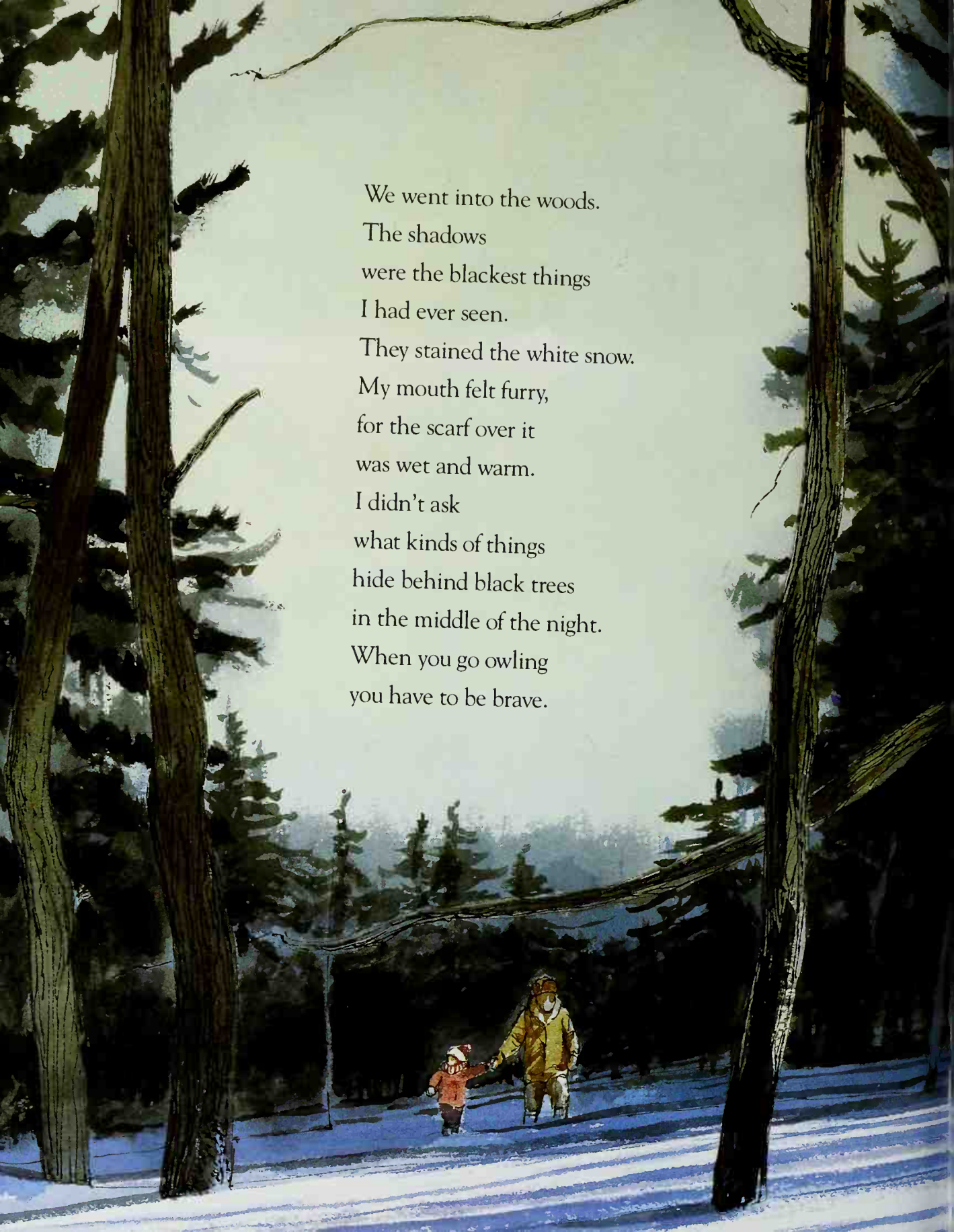




We walked on.
I could feel the cold,
as if someone's icy hand
was palm-down on my back.
And my nose
and the tops of my cheeks
felt cold and hot
at the same time.
But I never said a word.
If you go owling
you have to be quiet
and make your own heat.



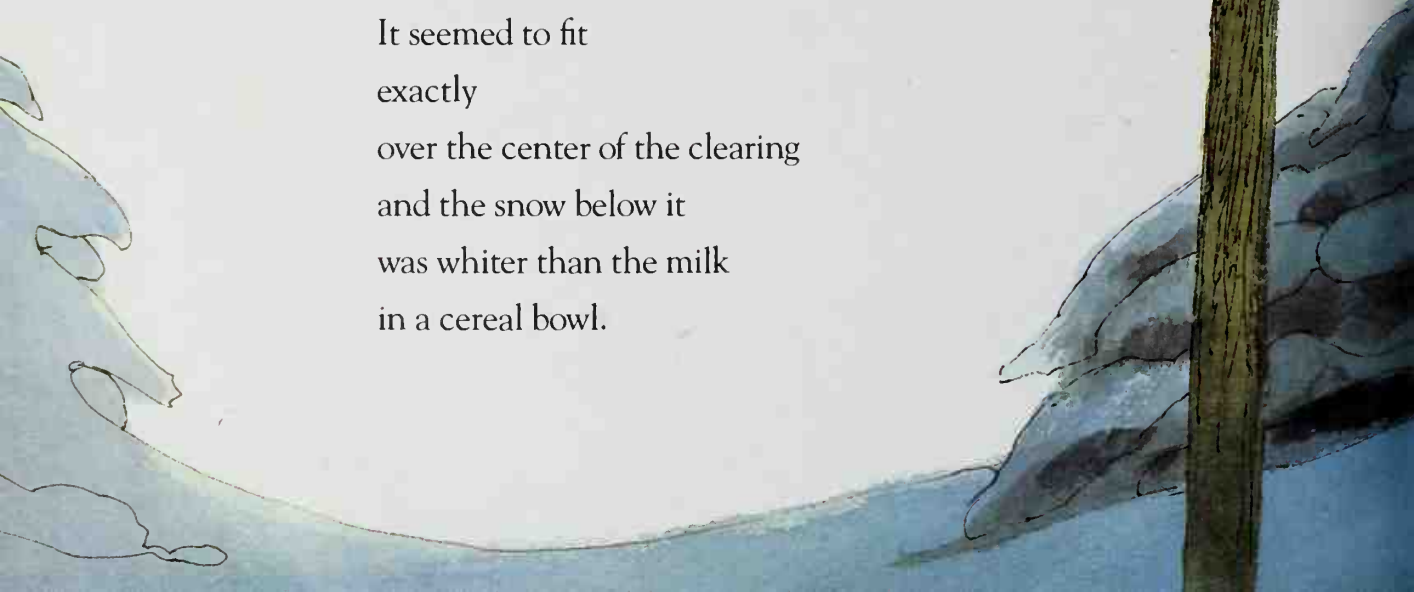
We went into the woods.
The shadows
were the blackest things
I had ever seen.
They stained the white snow.
My mouth felt furry,
for the scarf over it
was wet and warm.
I didn't ask
what kinds of things
hide behind black trees
in the middle of the night.
When you go owling
you have to be brave.







Then we came to a clearing
in the dark woods.
The moon was high above us.
It seemed to fit
exactly
over the center of the clearing
and the snow below it
was whiter than the milk
in a cereal bowl.









I sighed
and Pa held up his hand
at the sound.

I put my mittens
over the scarf
over my mouth
and listened hard.

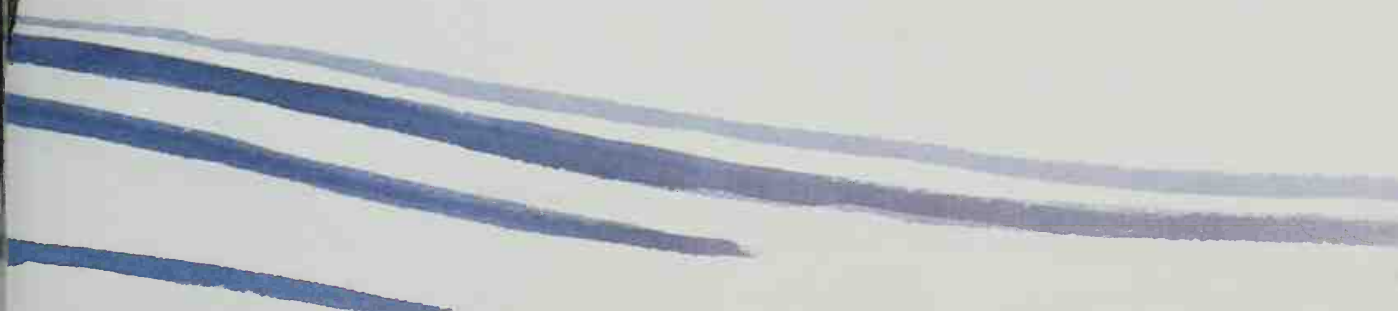
And then Pa called:

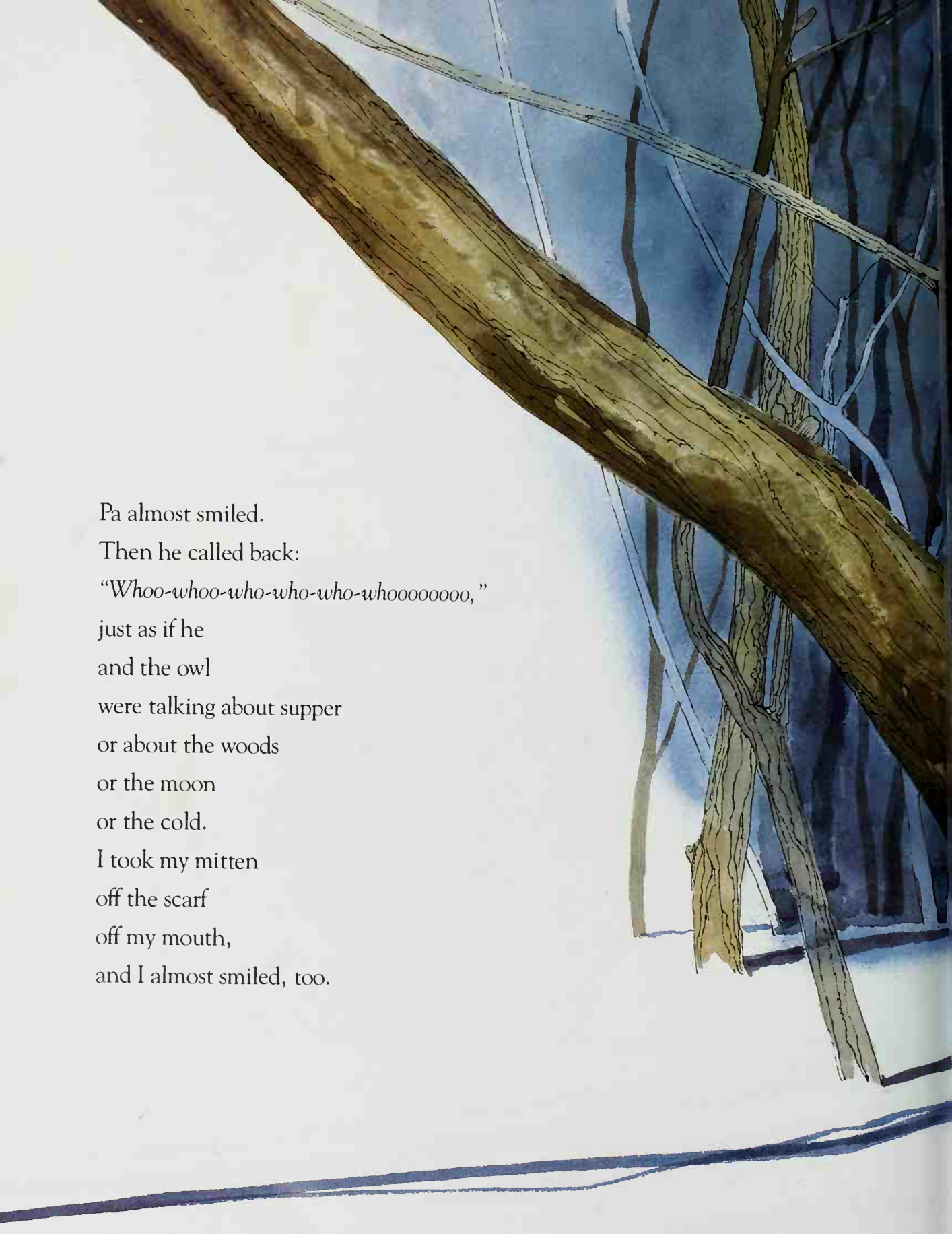
*"Whoo-whoo-who-who-who-whoooooooo.
Whoo-whoo-who-who-who-whoooooooo."*

I listened
and looked so hard
my ears hurt
and my eyes got cloudy
with the cold.

Pa raised his face
to call out again,
but before he could
open his mouth
an echo
came threading its way
through the trees.

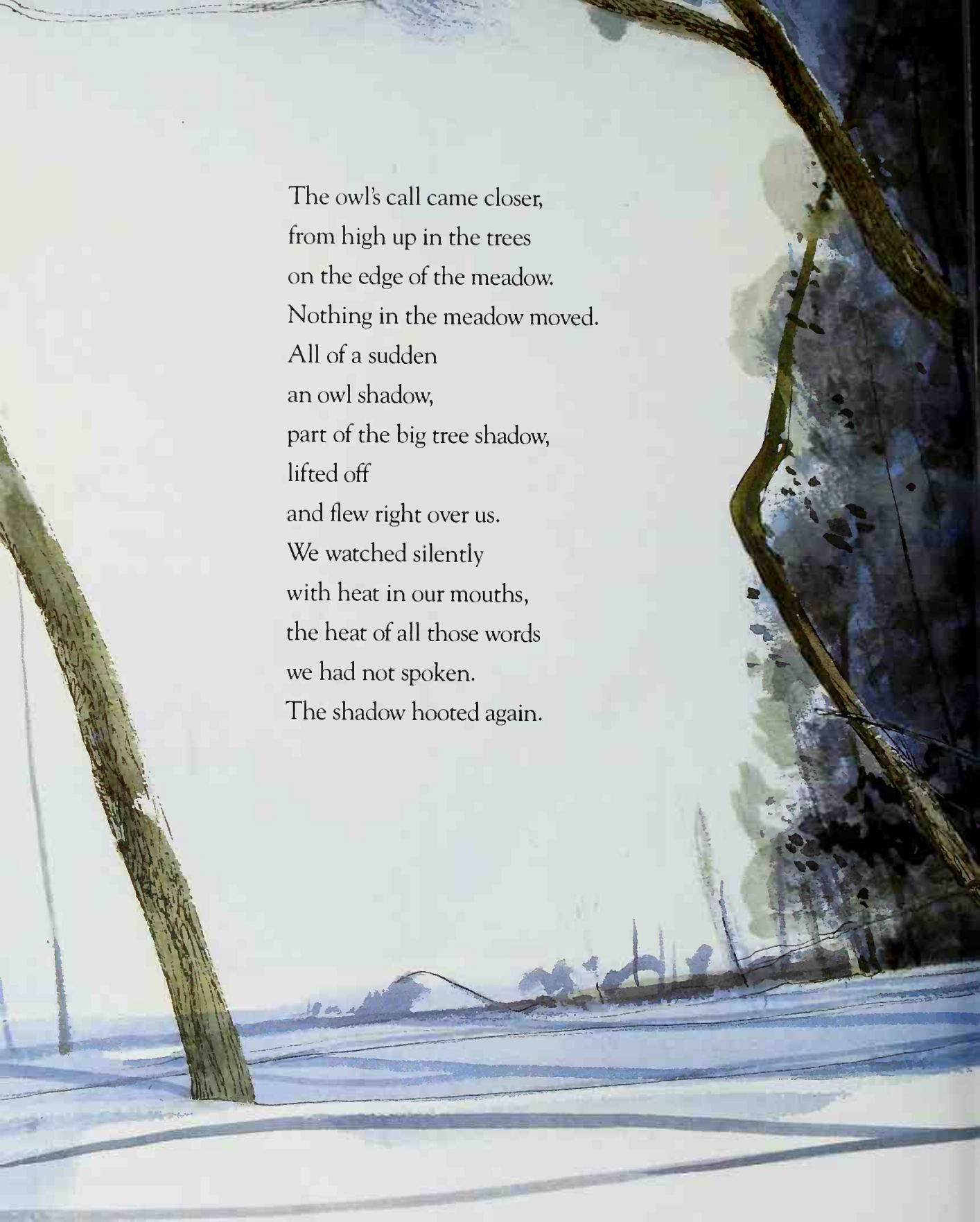
"Whoo-whoo-who-who-who-whoooooooo."





Pa almost smiled.
Then he called back:
“Whoo-whoo-who-who-who-whooooooooo,”
just as if he
and the owl
were talking about supper
or about the woods
or the moon
or the cold.
I took my mitten
off the scarf
off my mouth,
and I almost smiled, too.





The owl's call came closer,
from high up in the trees
on the edge of the meadow.
Nothing in the meadow moved.
All of a sudden
an owl shadow,
part of the big tree shadow,
lifted off
and flew right over us.
We watched silently
with heat in our mouths,
the heat of all those words
we had not spoken.
The shadow hooted again.

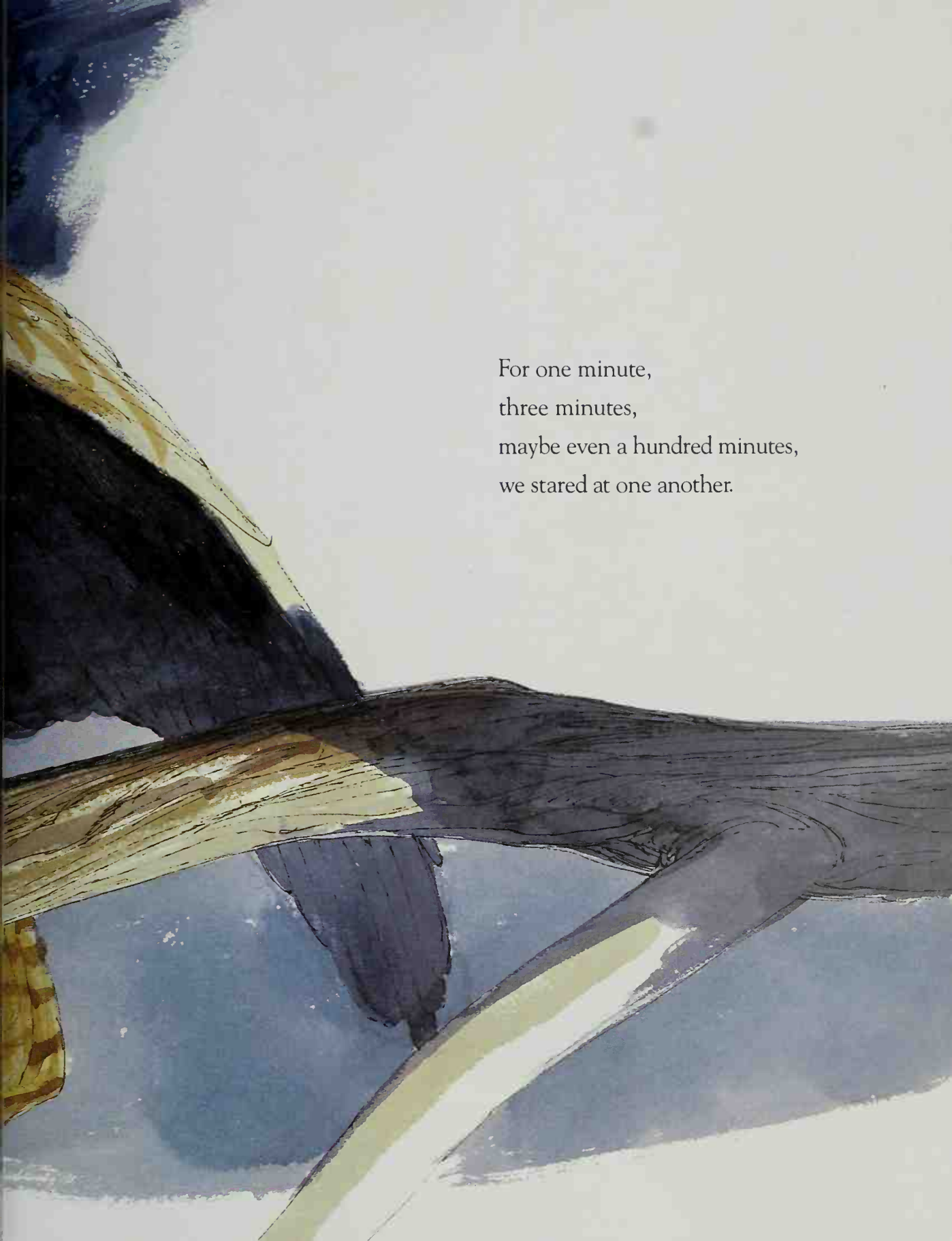




Pa turned on
his big flashlight
and caught the owl
just as it was landing
on a branch.







For one minute,
three minutes,
maybe even a hundred minutes,
we stared at one another.





Then the owl
pumped its great wings
and lifted off the branch
like a shadow
without sound.
It flew back into the forest.
“Time to go home,”
Pa said to me.
I knew then I could talk,
I could even laugh out loud.
But I was a shadow
as we walked home.

When you go owling
you don't need words
or warm
or anything but hope.
That's what Pa says.
The kind of hope
that flies
on silent wings
under a shining
Owl Moon.



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ONE WINTER'S NIGHT UNDER A FULL MOON

father and daughter walk into the woods in search of a Great Horned Owl.

Here are some activities to do with your child before, during, and after you read the book together. Don't try to do everything the first time you read it. And most of all have fun and enjoy sharing this story with your child.

STARTING UP

- Look at the cover together. Point to the moon and the soft colors. Ask your child, "Is it night or day?"
- After reading the title, ask your child where the owl is. (Hint: Look at the back cover too!)

READING THE STORY

- The girl does everything her father does. In each scene, point out what the father is doing. Ask your child, "Is the girl doing the same thing?"
- The sounds and silences of the story are musical.
 - Make the howling sounds of the dogs and the train, "howwwwooo, whoowhooo." Sing the owl sounds, too.
 - Whisper as you read the story aloud to show the quiet of the woods.
 - Papa holds up his hand so his daughter will stop walking. Show "stop" by putting your hand up at that point in the story.
- This story takes place in the country. Point out country things, such as the barn and the fields.
- The pictures show shadows in the snow. Ask your child what each shadow belongs to.

AFTER THE STORY

- Ask your child questions about the story
 - Was it hard or easy for the girl to be quiet? How can you tell?
- Learning on the Go:
 - Take a nighttime walk together to look for shadows.
 - Read a children's book about nocturnal animals.



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